CHAPTER 10

Vectors, lines and planes in space

S3, S6, S12, S15; synthesis S17

Objectives

Calculate with vectors; use collinearity and coplanarity; characterise lines and planes; work in a frame of reference.

Course notes

Vector calculus

Chasles's relation $\overrightarrow{AB} + \overrightarrow{BC} = \overrightarrow{AC}$, the sum of vectors and the product by a real number extend to space. Two non-zero vectors are collinear if one is a multiple of the other. The zero vector is collinear with every vector. Three vectors are coplanar if they belong to the same vector plane. If $\vec{u}, \vec{v}$ are not collinear, $\vec{u}, \vec{v}, \vec{w}$ are coplanar if and only if $\vec{w} = \alpha\vec{u} + \beta\vec{v}$ for some real numbers α, β.

Line and plane

The line through A with non-zero direction vector $\vec{u}$ is the set of points M such that $\overrightarrow{AM} = t\vec{u}$ for a real number t. The plane through A spanned by two non-collinear vectors $\vec{u}, \vec{v}$ is the set of points M such that $\overrightarrow{AM} = s\vec{u} + t\vec{v}$ for real numbers s, t.

Three non-collinear points define a plane. Four points A, B, C, D, with A, B, C not collinear, are coplanar if and only if $\overrightarrow{AD}$ is a linear combination of $\overrightarrow{AB}$ and $\overrightarrow{AC}$.

Relative positions

Two lines are coincident, strictly parallel, intersecting or non-coplanar (skew). Collinear direction vectors characterise parallel lines in the broad sense. Non-collinear direction vectors do not guarantee an intersection. A line and a plane: line contained in the plane, parallel and disjoint, or meeting it in a single point. Two planes: coincident, strictly parallel, or intersecting along a line.

Example in a cube. In $ABCDEFGH$, the faces $ABCD$ and $EFGH$ are parallel and the edges AE, BF, CG, DH correspond to one another. The lines (AB) and (CG) are neither parallel nor intersecting: they are non-coplanar.

Basis and coordinates

A basis of space is a family of three non-coplanar vectors. Every vector can be written uniquely in it as $x\vec{\imath} + y\vec{\jmath} + z\vec{k}$. A frame of reference consists of an origin O and a basis.

$$\overrightarrow{AB} = (x_B - x_A, y_B - y_A, z_B - z_A), \qquad I = \left(\frac{x_A + x_B}{2}, \frac{y_A + y_B}{2}, \frac{z_A + z_B}{2}\right).$$

In an orthonormal frame, $\|\vec{u}\| = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2 + z^2}$ and $AB = \sqrt{(x_B - x_A)^2 + (y_B - y_A)^2 + (z_B - z_A)^2}$.

Example. In an orthonormal frame, for $A(1,0,2)$, $B(3,-1,4)$, $\overrightarrow{AB} = (2,-1,2)$, $AB = 3$ and the midpoint is $(2,-\frac{1}{2},3)$.

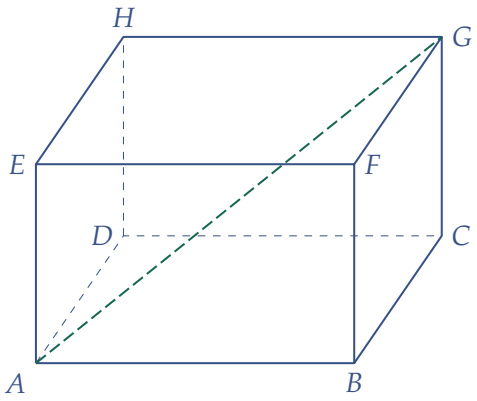
Testing a linear combination

Write the three coordinate equalities. Determine the coefficients from two equations when possible, then check the third. A contradiction proves non-membership; do not discard the awkward equation.

Research activity

Three midpoints in a cube — 40 min.

Consider the cube $ABCDEFGH$ shown below. Let $\vec{\imath} = \overrightarrow{AB}$, $\vec{\jmath} = \overrightarrow{AD}$ and $\vec{k} = \overrightarrow{AE}$. The points I, J and K are the midpoints of $[AB]$, $[AD]$ and $[AE]$ respectively. Let O be the centre of the cube.



$[AG]$ is a space diagonal, drawn dotted in green.
The hidden edges are dashed in blue; D and F are not on (AG).

1. Express $\overrightarrow{IJ}$ and $\overrightarrow{IK}$ in the basis $(\vec{\imath},\vec{\jmath},\vec{k})$.
2. Prove that the points I, J and K are not collinear.
3. Determine whether O belongs to the plane (IJK). Justify the answer by investigating whether $\overrightarrow{IO}$ is a linear combination of $\overrightarrow{IJ}$ and $\overrightarrow{IK}$.
4. Why does simply reading the figure not allow one to prove that O does or does not belong to the plane (IJK)?

Progressive exercises

E1 · Practice. In a basis of space, the vectors $\vec{u}$ and $\vec{v}$ have coordinates $(1;2;-1)$ and $(3;6;-3)$ respectively. Are they collinear? Justify.

E2 · Practice. In an orthonormal frame of space, consider $A(0;1;2)$ and $B(4;-1;0)$. Determine the coordinates of the midpoint of $[AB]$, then calculate the distance AB.

E3 · Practice. In a basis of space, consider $\vec{u} = (1;0;1)$, $\vec{v} = (0;1;1)$ and $\vec{w} = (2;3;5)$. Express $\vec{w}$ as a linear combination of $\vec{u}$ and $\vec{v}$, then deduce that these three vectors are coplanar.

E4 · Practice. In a basis of space, the vectors $\vec{u}$, $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ have coordinates $(1;0;1)$, $(0;1;1)$ and $(1;1;0)$. Is the triple $(\vec{u},\vec{v},\vec{w})$ a basis of space? Justify.

E5 · Practice. In a frame of space, consider $A(1;0;2)$, $B(3;-1;4)$ and $C(5;-2;6)$. Determine whether C belongs to the line (AB). Justify with a vector calculation.

Textbook or past-paper work

Barbazo, p. 328, exercise 21. In class after S15: do all three questions. For each intersection, begin by identifying each of the planes from the vertices of the cube and the midpoints given. Distinguish between intersecting, coincident and strictly parallel planes.

Homework

Homework 10 — Points of a tetrahedron — 50 min.

Consider a non-degenerate tetrahedron $ABCD$. The points I, J and K are the midpoints of $[AB]$, $[AC]$ and $[AD]$ respectively.

1. Express $\overrightarrow{IJ}$ in terms of $\overrightarrow{BC}$ and $\overrightarrow{IK}$ in terms of $\overrightarrow{BD}$.
2. Deduce that the planes (IJK) and (BCD) are parallel.
3. The point G is defined by $\overrightarrow{AG} = \frac{1}{4}(\overrightarrow{AB} + \overrightarrow{AC} + \overrightarrow{AD})$. Does the point G belong to the plane (IJK)? Justify.
4. For this question only, assume that, in an orthonormal frame, $A(0;0;0)$, $B(4;0;0)$, $C(0;4;0)$ and $D(0;0;4)$. Calculate the lengths IJ, IK and JK.